

cruellest sport at times, and his third-set retirement had to bring back bad memories from the 2021 French Open. Then, the 18-year-old Musetti grabbed the opening two sets against No. 1 Djokovic before a lower back injury forced him to retire in the fifth set. Once again, Musetti's fate was summed up in the eloquence of poet John Greenleaf Whittier: *"For of all sad words of tongue or pen, / The saddest are these: 'It might have been!'"*

This time, Musetti appeared on the verge of victory as Djokovic "underperformed" — his understated words — and looked every bit his advanced tennis age. Even so, high-energy Lorenzo, 23, caused much of that. While overshadowed by his more powerful and efficient compatriot Sinner, Musetti displays more flair, panache and joy. He led 6-4, 6-3, but his groin pain worsened. Trailing 3-1 in the third set, Lorenzo had to retire once again. "He should have been a winner today, no doubt," conceded the gracious Djokovic.

For the first time in the Open Era, the top six men's and women's singles seeds reached the last eight at a Grand Slam event.

The dominance by the leading men and lower seeds resulted in few early-round upsets. The most notable were Spizzirri's four-setter victory over much-touted but erratic 28th seed Joao Fonseca and Nuno Borges's elimination of seventh seed Felix Auger-Aliassime. One of the tour's fittest athletes, Auger-Aliassime retired after three sets due to cramps. "I feel for him," said the empathetic Borges. "I know how he feels to struggle physically and it is part of tennis."

Shelton extended his demoralising 0-17 record against top-three opponents when Sinner repeated his 7-6(2), 6-2, 6-2 thrashing in the AO semifinals a year ago with a similar 6-3, 6-4,

6-4 decision. The exuberant 23-year-old American's pulverising serve couldn't compensate for his inferior groundstrokes, particularly his erratic backhand.

"We'll find out how big that gap is between Sinner and Alcaraz and the rest of the field," said *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe before the semifinals.

If the first week lacked drama, two semifinal blockbusters and a high-quality final featuring the elite provided a thrilling climax.

The 'Happy Slam' — the tournament's nickname — turned into the 'Lucky Slam' for Djokovic. He hadn't won a set in six days. In the rust-versus-rest debate, Djokovic's highly grooved, impeccable strokes and vast experience made the verdict easy. As *Tennis Channel* analyst Chris Eubanks said, "This is as ideal a situation as Djokovic could have imagined."

When they entered Rod Laver Arena, Djokovic received twice the ovation of Sinner. It quickly became clear he'd need their energy.

Sinner had won 10 straight sets against Djokovic. The heavy-hitting Italian raced to a 3-0 lead in just eight minutes. When he clinched the

opening 6-3 set with a backhand winner, he looked like Djokovic 2.0 — a better, much younger version of the GOAT.

Battle of eras

But the perfectionist Serb had planned for this slugfest scenario. Compared to 2023 — when he captured three Grand Slam titles — Djokovic's forehand speed this year averaged 5 mph more, his backhand 2 mph faster, and, most critically, his second serve 8 mph quicker. Tactically, he used his down-the-line forehand to great effect. "Obsession is the greatest strength of the best, the elite," observed John Fitzgerald, the pithy *Australian TV* analyst.

The crowd roared and Serbian partisans raised bright tricolour flags when their hero broke serve for a 3-1 lead in the second set. He then clinched the set 6-3 with a forehand cross-court winner. But could he maintain this phenomenal level?

Sinner recovered to take the third set 6-4. Yet Djokovic, the fittest champion since Bjorn Borg 50 years ago, rebounded to level the match at two sets apiece by winning the fourth 6-4. He escaped two break points at 4-3 as chants of "Nole! Nole!" reverberated around the arena.

More telling now than Sinner's 14-year age advantage was Djokovic's 40-11 record in five-set matches versus 6-10 for Sinner. Equally relevant was 1960s Australian star Fred Stolle's timeless maxim: "The most important stat in men's tennis is break points converted."

Djokovic drew first blood with a service break for 1-0. Serving at 4-3, he faced a huge crisis — triple break point. "Close it out. C'mon!" exhorted coach Darren Cahill. But Sinner couldn't find that elusive break as Djokovic saved all eight break points in the deciding set and a stunning 16 of 18 for the match.

After his 3-6, 6-3, 4-6, 6-4, 6-4 triumph that ended at 1.32 a.m., Djokovic told the crowd, "It feels surreal, to be honest, playing four hours, almost 2 a.m., reminiscent of 2012 when I played Rafa in the final."

Djoker then quipped,



Mind over game: Sinner lost the mental battle in the semifinal against Djokovic to succumb in an epic five-setter. GETTY IMAGES